

Usability Testing

Watch users attempt real tasks; note friction

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Usability testing observes representative users attempting realistic tasks with a prototype or product, recording where they succeed, hesitate or fail. It measures whether the design actually works for people, rather than whether they say they like it.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Established in HCI and championed by Jakob Nielsen and the Nielsen Norman Group; Nielsen argued five users find most usability problems.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Designers cannot see their own product's flaws. Watching real users reveals friction the team is blind to, cheaply and early.

FIGURE 1 · DIMINISHING RETURNS PER USER

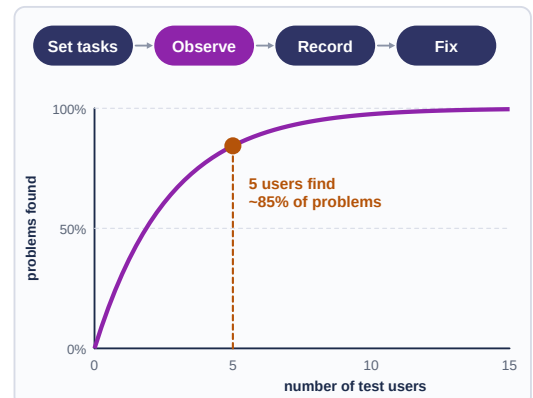


Figure 1. Nielsen's curve: a few representative users surface most usability problems, so test small and often.

HOW IT IS USED

Set real tasks, ask users to think aloud, observe without helping, and log issues by severity, iterating between rounds.

WHEN IT IS USED

Throughout the Test phase and continuously as a product evolves.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

UX researchers, designers and product teams.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It privileges **observed behaviour over stated opinion**, and Nielsen's 'five users' insight made rigorous testing affordable for any team.

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Feedback Capture Grid *Slibrary 9*

Solution Interview *Slibrary 9*

Paper / Low-fi Prototype *Slibrary 8*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Nielsen, J. (1993) *Usability Engineering*. San Francisco: Morgan Kaufmann.

Nielsen, J. (2000) 'Why You Only Need to Test with 5 Users', *Nielsen Norman Group*. Available at: <https://www.nngroup.com/articles/why-you-only-need-to-test-with-5-users/> (Accessed: 20 July 2026).